At this point, you still haven't really identified any value that the requested system might deliver, so you could follow up with another question: "Why is that a problem for us?" To which the director relies, "Because revenue from the classified ads service is falling."

So now at least you're talking about financial impact. Because you're still getting answers, you might press your luck a bit further: "And why will entering the ads online stop our classified ads revenue from falling?" To which the director answers, "Because more people will be able to browse our classified ads online."

"So, to make sure I have the whole picture," you reply, "how will more people seeing our ads online stop our classified ads revenue from falling?"

"Well, if more people can browse the ads online, the products are likely to sell faster. We earn a commission on each sale, so the faster the products sell, the more we earn."

So here we have a clear mapping back to a measurable business goal: you want to place the ads online so that more people will see the ads and hopefully purchase the advertised goods. Because the company earns a commission on each item sold, this will increase the classified ads revenue.

This process, sometimes known as "popping the why stack," is a powerful analysis tool. Discovering and crystalizing the value proposition behind the features that users ask for not only helps you understand why they're asking for these features but also puts you in a position to evaluate their relative value and to adapt them to changing circumstances.

We'll develop this concept further in the next chapter. But first, let's look at how you can discover what capabilities a system will need to realize its business goals.

EXERCISE 3.4 Management has asked for a feature that can send SMS alerts to managers whenever a bus company claims to have run more trips than they did according to the real-time data. Team up with a colleague, with one person playing the role of the business stakeholder. Use the "popping the why stack" approach to identify the underlying business goal. Once you've identified a goal, discuss whether this is the only or best way to deliver this goal.

3.5 Impact Mapping: a visual approach

In Feature Injection, the "hunt the value" step involves identifying how your project will deliver value to the organization. In the second step, "inject the feature," you flush out the features that can deliver this value. In his book *Impact Mapping* (Provoking Thoughts, 2012), Gojko Adzic describes an interesting, visually-based approach to the problem of aligning the software features you deliver with the underlying business goals.

Impact Mapping is a way of visualizing the relationship between the business goals behind a project, the actors that will be affected by the project, and the features that will enable the project to deliver the expected results. Impact maps are simple to create and easy to understand, and they can be a very useful tool for documenting business goals and validating assumptions. This makes them a great place to kick off